DOCUMENTATION

Documentation guide

How we write progress notes, treatment plans and discharge summaries at Cedar Grove, with timelines and a sample note.

THE STANDARD

Every progress note follows SOAP and is finished within 24 hours of the session.

TREATMENT PLANS

Written with the client by the third session and reviewed every 90 days.

RISK

Any risk screen, safety plan or consultation is written up the same day.

Why notes matter

Good notes protect the client, the clinician and the practice. They show what happened, why, and what comes next.

- Clear
- Timely
- Clinical

Our standard: SOAP

Every progress note follows SOAP: Subjective, Objective, Assessment, Plan. Keep each part short.

- S: what the client reports
- O: what you observe
- A: your clinical view
- P: next steps

Writing the Subjective

Use the client's own words where they matter. Summarize the rest.

- Quote sparingly
- Note changes since last session
- Include stressors

Writing the Objective

Record what you saw and measured: affect, appearance, scores on any measures.

- Mental status
- Measures (PHQ-9, GAD-7)
- Behavior in session

Writing the Assessment

Tie what you heard and saw to the treatment plan. Is the client improving, stable or worse?

- Progress on goals
- Risk level
- Diagnosis updates

Writing the Plan

Name the next step: interventions, homework, referrals and the next appointment.

- Next session date
- Homework
- Referrals

Timelines

Notes are due within 24 hours. Late notes delay billing and weaken the record.

- 24 hours for progress notes
- Same day for crisis notes
- 7 days for discharge

Treatment plans

Write the plan by the third session, with the client. Review it every 90 days.

- Problem
- Goals
- Objectives
- Review date

Risk documentation

Any risk screen, safety plan or consultation is written up the same day, in full.

- Screen used
- Plan made
- Who you consulted

Telehealth notes

Add the client's location, the platform and that consent for telehealth is on file.

- Location
- Platform
- Consent on file

Couples and family notes

Write one note per session, naming who attended. Keep individual disclosures out of shared notes.

- Who attended
- Shared goals
- No secrets in the shared record

Late entries and corrections

Never delete. Add a dated addendum that explains the correction.

- Addendum, not edit
- Date and sign
- Explain why

Language to avoid

Avoid labels, slang and judgment. Describe behavior instead.

- “Client was tearful” not “client was dramatic”
- No abbreviations clients cannot read
- No opinions about character

Records requests

Clients can ask for their records. Send every request to the front desk; never email records yourself.

- Front desk handles requests
- Verify identity
- Log what was sent

Audits

The director reviews a sample of charts each quarter. You will get feedback, not a grade.

- Quarterly sample
- Written feedback
- Fix within two weeks

Quick checklist

Before you sign a note, check these five things.

- Date and length
- All four SOAP parts
- Risk addressed
- Plan and next date
- Signed

Sample note

S: Client reports sleeping better, still anxious before work. O: Calm, engaged, GAD-7 = 9 (was 13). A: Improving on goal 1. P: Continue exposure practice; next session in one week.